CRIMINALIZING REPORTING

Belarus v. Katsiaryna Andreyeva and Daria Chultsova

9 October 2026

CASE FOLLOW-UP REPORT

Procedural developments and verified outcomes

Independent research based on user-supplied TrialWatch materials

ABOUT THIS UPDATE

This independent research update follows the user-supplied TrialWatch material. It is not issued by the Clooney Foundation for Justice, TrialWatch, or the original authors. The earlier report supplies the historical baseline; later developments are supported by the sources cited here.

Jurisdiction	Belarus
Original report	October 2021
Dated update covered	24 March 2026
Research cutoff	9 October 2026
Historical assessment	TrialWatch grade D (original report only)

SCOPE AND METHOD

Research considered public court records, enacted legislation, lawyers and subjects, press-freedom organizations, United Nations materials and attributable reporting available through 9 October 2026. Publication dates and event dates are distinguished. Where judgments or current custody records could not be obtained, the conclusion is expressly qualified. No direct interviews or new trial monitoring were conducted for this update.

An acquittal, quashing order, pardon, sentence completion, bail decision and custody transfer have different legal effects. A reported intention to litigate is separated from an actual filing. Unresolved questions are listed below. Historical TrialWatch grades retain their original attribution; this update does not assign a new grade.

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

LATEST VERIFIED POSITION

Chultsova released in 2022; Andreyeva pardoned and released in March 2026

Latest dated follow-up is PEN International's 24 March response to the 19 March release. Chultsova's September 2022 release followed completion of her term; Andreyeva's 2026 release followed a pardon after a separate treason conviction. Neither event establishes that either original conviction was quashed.

Katsiaryna Andreyeva was pardoned and released on 19 March 2026, after more than five years in custody. CPJ confirmed her transfer to Lithuania; PEN International's 24 March statement subsequently addressed the release and exile of the freed group. This was not a 2025 pardon or an acquittal. [5] [6]

Daria Chultsova had already been released in September 2022 after serving her sentence. A September 2025 Belarusian Association of Journalists report placed her in Poland. The defendants therefore have different post-report trajectories, despite sharing the prosecution monitored in 2021. [4] [7]

4. Belarusian Association of Journ..., 5 September 2022. Belsat journalist Darya Chultsova released af...
5. Committee to Protect Journalists, 19 March 2026. Belarusian journalist Katsiaryna Andreyeva re...
6. PEN International, 24 March 2026. Belarus: Immediately release all those still...
7. Belarusian Association of Journ..., 16 September 2025. Journalist Ihar Ilyash sentenced to four year...

BACKGROUND AND PROCEDURAL HISTORY

The October 2021 report examined the prosecution arising from the journalists' live coverage of a memorial protest for Raman Bandarenka on 15 November 2020. Andreyeva was reporting and Chultsova operating the camera from an apartment overlooking the gathering. The Frunzensky District Court in Minsk convicted both under Article 342, concerning actions grossly violating public order, and imposed two-year prison sentences on 18 February 2021. [1]

TrialWatch expert Beth Van Schaack assigned the monitored proceedings a D. The report questioned the equation of journalism with protest organization, the evidentiary basis for attributing transport disruption to the defendants, restrictions on defense questioning and documentary evidence, and judicial impartiality and the presumption of innocence. That assessment concerned the February 2021 hearings. It did not monitor the later closed treason proceedings against Andreyeva. [1]

KEY PROCEDURAL DATES

18 February 2021	Both defendants convicted and sentenced to two years in the monitored public-order case. [1]
13 July 2022	Andreyeva convicted of treason in a separate closed proceeding; CPJ reported an additional eight-year sentence. [2]
September 2022	Chultsova released after serving her term; BAJ published confirmation on 5 September. [4]
20 September 2022	BAJ reported the Supreme Court upheld Andreyeva's effective sentence of eight years and three months. [3]
16 September 2025	BAJ's dated reporting described Chultsova as living in Poland. [7]
19 March 2026	Andreyeva pardoned, released and transferred to Lithuania. [5]
24 March 2026	PEN International condemned the forced exile accompanying the recent releases. [6]

1. User-supplied original report, October 2021.
2. Committee to Protect Journalists, 13 July 2022. Belarusian journalist Katsiaryna Andreyeva co...
3. Belarusian Association of Journ..., 20 September 2022. Espionage: Supreme Court changed wording in K...
4. Belarusian Association of Journ..., 5 September 2022. Belsat journalist Darya Chultsova released af...
5. Committee to Protect Journalists, 19 March 2026. Belarusian journalist Katsiaryna Andreyeva re...
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SUBSEQUENT DEVELOPMENTS

Andreyeva's continued imprisonment was not simply the original two-year term running its course. CPJ reported that a court in Homel convicted her of treason on 13 July 2022 after a closed trial. Details of the alleged conduct were not publicly established in that account. The additional prosecution must be treated independently of the public-order charges and the evidence examined by TrialWatch. [2]

On 20 September 2022, BAJ reported an unsuccessful Supreme Court appeal and an effective sentence of eight years and three months. Citing Andreyeva's husband, it said the description of the treason allegation changed from disclosure of state secrets to espionage without changing the outcome. This is an attributed account, not independent access to the sealed judgment. [3]

BAJ confirmed Chultsova's release in early September 2022 after completion of her sentence. Public sources vary over the precise day; this report uses the month rather than converting BAJ's publication date into a release date. Her later presence in Poland is separately documented, rather than inferred from the original sentence length. [4] [7]

CPJ linked the March release to a negotiated package and confirmed Andreyeva's pardon and transfer to Lithuania without passports. PEN International welcomed release but characterized the accompanying exile as coercive. These assessments are attributed to those organizations. [5] [6]

LEGAL AND PROCEDURAL ASSESSMENT

The following assessment draws inferences from the cited record. It does not represent a new court finding or TrialWatch grade.

the shared trial no longer supplies a single status for both defendants. Completion of Chultsova's term and Andreyeva's later pardon are legally different routes out of custody. The separate treason case explains why the original two-year sentence cannot establish Andreyeva's release date. [1] [2] [4] [5]

release improves physical liberty without establishing judicial rehabilitation. A pardon does not validate the trial or establish innocence. Reported forced departure also prevents an assumption of unconditional restoration of the journalists' previous lives. [5] [6]

1. User-supplied original report, October 2021.
2. Committee to Protect Journalists, 13 July 2022. Belarusian journalist Katsiaryna Andreyeva co...
3. Belarusian Association of Journ..., 20 September 2022. Espionage: Supreme Court changed wording in K...
4. Belarusian Association of Journ..., 5 September 2022. Belsat journalist Darya Chultsova released af...
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CONCLUSION AND OUTSTANDING RECORDS

Both defendants have verified releases, reached through different procedures. The follow-up should preserve the original attributed grade, describe the later treason case separately, and leave the continuing legal effects of both convictions expressly unresolved.

RECORDS NOT VERIFIED

1. Exact day of Chultsova's September 2022 release: contemporaneous accounts and later profiles differ between 3 and 5 September.

2. Full judgments and publicly reviewable evidence in Andreyeva's treason proceedings, including the precise calculation of the reported eight-year-three-month effective sentence.

3. Scope and legal conditions of Andreyeva's individual pardon, including whether criminal records, civil restrictions or return rights changed.

4. Any subsequent judgment vacating either defendant's 2021 conviction; no such disposition was verified through the cutoff.

Failure to locate an update leaves a gap in the available evidence; it does not establish that no later proceeding or change occurred. Any present-status claim should be read with the dated scope stated in the executive summary.

SOURCES AND REFERENCES

Numbered references correspond to superscript citations and page notes. Web sources were consulted for this research through 9 October 2026. Original reports are local user-supplied files. Each link opens the cited source.

1. **Original user-supplied report on Belarus v. Katsiaryna Andreyeva and Daria Chultsova**
TrialWatch / original report authors. October 2021.
Local PDF: belarus-v-katsiaryna-andreyeva-and-daria-chultsova.pdf
Coverage: Historical case baseline and original assessment

2. **Belarusian journalist Katsiaryna Andreyeva convicted of treason, sentenced to additional 8 years imprisonment**
Committee to Protect Journalists. 13 July 2022.
Read source at cpj.org
Coverage: Separate closed treason trial; sentence announced 13 July 2022

3. **Espionage: Supreme Court changed wording in Katsiaryna Andreyeva's case while upholding verdict**
Belarusian Association of Journalists. 20 September 2022.
Read source at baj.media
Coverage: Appeal upheld; reported effective sentence; husband's account of changed wording

4. **Belsat journalist Darya Chultsova released after two years in penal colony**
Belarusian Association of Journalists. 5 September 2022.
Read source at baj.media
Coverage: Release after serving term; publication date is not asserted as exact release date

5. **Belarusian journalist Katsiaryna Andreyeva released after serving over 5 years in prison**
Committee to Protect Journalists. 19 March 2026.
Read source at cpj.org
Coverage: Actual release and pardon on 19 March; transfer to Lithuania without passports

6. **Belarus: Immediately release all those still unjustly imprisoned**
PEN International. 24 March 2026.
Read source at www.pen-international.org
Coverage: Follow-up response to March releases; forced-exile assessment

7. **Journalist Ihar Ilyash sentenced to four years in prison**
Belarusian Association of Journalists. 16 September 2025.
Read source at baj.media
Coverage: Chultsova described as living in Poland